

Hypertension in Pregnancy

High blood pressure conditions and pregnancy

Health care professionals can make the following diagnoses for pregnancy-related high blood pressure. Your doctor or nurse should look for these conditions before, during, and after pregnancy:

- **High blood pressure during pregnancy** occurs when a pregnant woman has a blood pressure reading of 140/90 mm Hg or higher in two readings that are 4 or more hours apart.
- **Severe high blood pressure during pregnancy** occurs when a pregnant woman has a blood pressure reading of 160/110 mm Hg on two or more occasions.
- **Chronic hypertension during pregnancy** is when a pregnant woman has pre-existing high blood pressure and is diagnosed in the first 20 weeks of pregnancy or if the high blood pressure lasts 12 weeks after the woman has given birth.
- **Gestational hypertension** is when a pregnant woman who previously had normal blood pressure has high blood pressure during pregnancy.
- **Preeclampsia** occurs when a woman who previously had normal blood pressure suddenly develops high blood pressure and protein is found in her urine or has other problems after 20 weeks of pregnancy. Women who have chronic hypertension can also get preeclampsia.
- **Eclampsia** is a medical emergency. Eclampsia is when a pregnant woman with preeclampsia has seizures that have no other cause.

Health care professionals can recommend low-dose aspirin for some pregnant women at higher risk of preeclampsia. If taken at the appropriate time, low-dose aspirin has been shown to reduce the risk of preeclampsia.

What are the high blood pressure complications during pregnancy?

High blood pressure can also cause problems during and after delivery. The good news is that high blood pressure is preventable and treatable.

High blood pressure, also called hypertension, is very common.

High blood pressure in pregnancy has become more common. However, with good blood pressure control, you and your baby are more likely to stay healthy.

The most important thing to do is talk with your health care team about any blood pressure problems so you can get the right treatment and control your blood pressure—**before** you get pregnant. Getting treatment for high blood pressure is important before, during, and after pregnancy.

Complications from high blood pressure for the mother and infant can include the following:

- **For the mother:** preeclampsia, eclampsia, stroke, the need for labor induction (giving medicine to start labor to give birth), and placental abruption (the placenta separating from the wall of the uterus).
- **For the baby:** preterm delivery (birth that happens before 37 weeks of pregnancy) and low birth weight (when a baby is born weighing less than 5 pounds, 8 ounces). When the mother's blood pressure is high, it is hard for the baby to get enough oxygen and nutrients to grow. This may cause the mother to deliver the baby early.

What should I do if I have high blood pressure before pregnancy?

Make a plan for pregnancy and talk with your doctor or health care team about the following:

- Any health problems you have or had or have any medicines you are taking. If you are planning to become pregnant, talk to your doctor.[7](#)
- Your doctor or health care team can help you find medicines that are safe to take during pregnancy.

- Ways to keep a healthy weight through healthy eating and regular physical activity.

What should I do if I have high blood pressure during pregnancy?

- Get early and regular prenatal care. Go to every appointment with your doctor or health care professional.
- Talk to your doctor about any medicines you take and which ones are safe. Do not stop or start taking any type of medicine without talking with your doctor. This includes over-the-counter medicines.
- Keep track of your blood pressure at home with a home blood pressure monitor. Contact your doctor if your blood pressure is higher than usual or if you have symptoms of pre-eclampsia.
- Talk to your doctor or insurance company about getting a home monitor.
- Continue to choose healthy foods and keep a healthy weight.

What should I do if I have high blood pressure after pregnancy?

- Pay attention to how you feel after you give birth. If you have high blood pressure during pregnancy, you have a higher risk of stroke and other problems after delivery.
- Tell your doctor right away if you have symptoms of preeclampsia after delivery. You might need emergency medical care.

Preeclampsia and eclampsia

Preeclampsia is one of the leading causes of pregnancy-related death. It occurs in about 2% to 8% of all pregnancies. Some women with preeclampsia can develop seizures. This is called **eclampsia**, which is a medical emergency.

Symptoms of preeclampsia include:

- A headache that will not go away.

- Changes in vision, including blurry vision, seeing spots, or having changes in eyesight.
- Pain in the upper stomach area.
- Nausea or vomiting.
- Swelling of the face or hands.
- Sudden weight gain.
- Trouble breathing.

Some women have no symptoms of preeclampsia. That's why it is important to visit your health care team regularly, especially during pregnancy.

You are more at risk for preeclampsia if:

- This is the first time you have given birth.
- You had preeclampsia during a previous pregnancy.
- You have chronic (long-term) high blood pressure, chronic kidney disease, or both.
- You have a history of thrombophilia (a condition that increases risk of blood clots).
- You are pregnant with multiple babies (such as twins or triplets).
- You became pregnant using in vitro fertilization.
- You have a family history of preeclampsia.
- You have type 1 or type 2 diabetes.
- You have obesity.
- You have lupus (an autoimmune disease).
- You are older than 40.

In rare cases, preeclampsia can happen after you have given birth. This is a serious medical condition known as **postpartum preeclampsia**. It can happen in women without any history of preeclampsia during pregnancy. The symptoms for postpartum preeclampsia are similar to the symptoms of preeclampsia. Postpartum preeclampsia is typically diagnosed within 48 hours after delivery but can happen up to 6 weeks later.

High blood pressure risk factors in pregnancy

Risk factors that can increase your risk of high blood pressure include health conditions, your lifestyle, and your family history.

Some of the risk factors for high blood pressure cannot be controlled, such as your age or family history. But you can take steps to lower your risk by changing the factors you can control.

Conditions that can increase risk

Some medical conditions can raise your risk for high blood pressure. These are elevated blood pressure or high normal blood pressure, diabetes and obesity. If you have one of these conditions, you can take steps to manage it and lower your risk for high blood pressure.

Elevated blood pressure

Elevated blood pressure is blood pressure that is slightly higher than normal. High blood pressure usually develops over time. Having blood pressure that is slightly higher than normal increases your risk for developing chronic high blood pressure.

If your blood pressure is between 120/80 mm Hg and 129/80 mm Hg, you have elevated blood pressure. Learn more about how blood pressure is measured.

You can take steps to manage your blood pressure and keep it in a healthy range.

Diabetes

Diabetes causes sugars to build up in the blood and also increases the risk for heart disease.

Talk with your doctor about ways to manage diabetes and control other risk factors.

Obesity

Having obesity is having excess body fat. Having obesity or overweight also means your heart must work harder to pump blood and oxygen around your body. Over time, this can add stress to your heart and blood vessels.

Obesity is linked to higher "bad" cholesterol and triglyceride levels and to lower "good" cholesterol levels.

In addition to high blood pressure, having obesity can also lead to heart disease and diabetes. Talk to your health care team about a plan to reduce your weight to a healthy level.

Pregnancy

Some women develop high blood pressure during pregnancy. This can put mother and baby at risk for problems during or after the pregnancy. If you are pregnant or planning to become pregnant, talk with your health care team about ways you can keep you and your baby safe.

Behaviors that can increase risk of high blood pressure in pregnancy

Your lifestyle choices can increase your risk for high blood pressure. To reduce your risk, your doctor may recommend changes to your lifestyle.

The good news is that healthy behaviors can lower your risk for high blood pressure.

Unhealthy diet

A diet that is too high in sodium and too low in potassium puts you at risk for high blood pressure.

Eating too much sodium—an element in table salt—increases blood pressure. Most of the sodium we eat comes from processed and restaurant foods.

Not eating enough potassium—a mineral that your body needs to work properly—also can increase blood pressure. Potassium is found in many foods; bananas, potatoes, beans, and yogurt have high levels of potassium.

Physical inactivity

Getting regular physical activity helps your heart and blood vessels stay strong and healthy, which may help lower your blood pressure. Regular physical activity can also help you keep a healthy weight, which may also help lower your blood pressure.

Too much alcohol

Drinking too much alcohol can raise your blood pressure.

- Women should have no more than one drink a day.
- Men should have no more than two drinks a day.

Tobacco use

Tobacco use increases your risk for high blood pressure. Smoking can damage the heart and blood vessels. Nicotine raises blood pressure, and breathing in carbon monoxide—which is produced from smoking tobacco—reduces the amount of oxygen that your blood can carry.

Family history of high blood pressure

The risk for high blood pressure can increase even more when heredity combines with unhealthy lifestyle choices, such as smoking and eating an unhealthy diet.

Family health history is a record of the diseases and health conditions people in your family have had. Family history of high blood pressure increases risk of high blood pressure.

Both men and women can have high blood pressure. Some other characteristics that you cannot control—such as your age, race, or ethnicity—can affect your risk for high blood pressure.

- **Age.** Because your blood pressure tends to rise as you get older, your risk for high blood pressure increases with age.
- **Sex.** Women are about as likely as men to develop high blood pressure at some point during their lives.
- **Race or ethnicity.** Black people have a high risk for developing high blood pressure

Preventing hypertension in pregnancy

Eat a healthy diet

Choose healthy meal and snack options to help you avoid high blood pressure and its complications. Be sure to eat plenty of fresh fruits and vegetables.

Talk with your health care team about eating a variety of foods rich in potassium, fiber, and protein and lower in salt (sodium) and saturated fat. For many people, making these healthy changes can help keep blood pressure low and protect against heart disease and stroke.

The DASH (Dietary Approaches to Stop Hypertension) eating plan is a healthy diet plan with a proven record of helping people lower their blood pressure.

Keep yourself at a healthy weight

Having overweight or obesity increases your risk for high blood pressure.

Talk with your health care team about ways to reach a healthy weight, including choosing healthy foods and getting regular physical activity.

Be physically active

Physical activity can help keep you at a healthy weight and lower your blood pressure. It is recommended to practice at least 2 hours and 30 minutes of moderate-intensity exercise, such as brisk walking or bicycling, every week. That's about 30 minutes a day, 5 days a week.

Do not smoke

Smoking raises your blood pressure and puts you at higher risk for heart attack and stroke. If you do not smoke, do not start. If you do smoke, quitting will lower your risk for heart disease. Your doctor can suggest ways to help you quit.

Limit how much alcohol you drink

Do not drink too much alcohol, which can raise your blood pressure. Men should have no more than 2 alcoholic drinks per day, and women should have no more than 1 alcoholic drink per day.

Get enough sleep

Getting enough sleep is important to your overall health. It also helps keep your heart and blood vessels healthy. Not getting enough sleep on a regular basis is linked to an increased risk of heart disease, high blood pressure, and stroke.

Manage stress

People who have depression, anxiety, stress, or post-traumatic stress disorder over a long period of time may develop other health problems, including an increased heart rate and high blood pressure.

Recognize the signs and symptoms of mental health disorders and heart disease. Talk with your health care team about potential heart conditions in relation to your mental health.